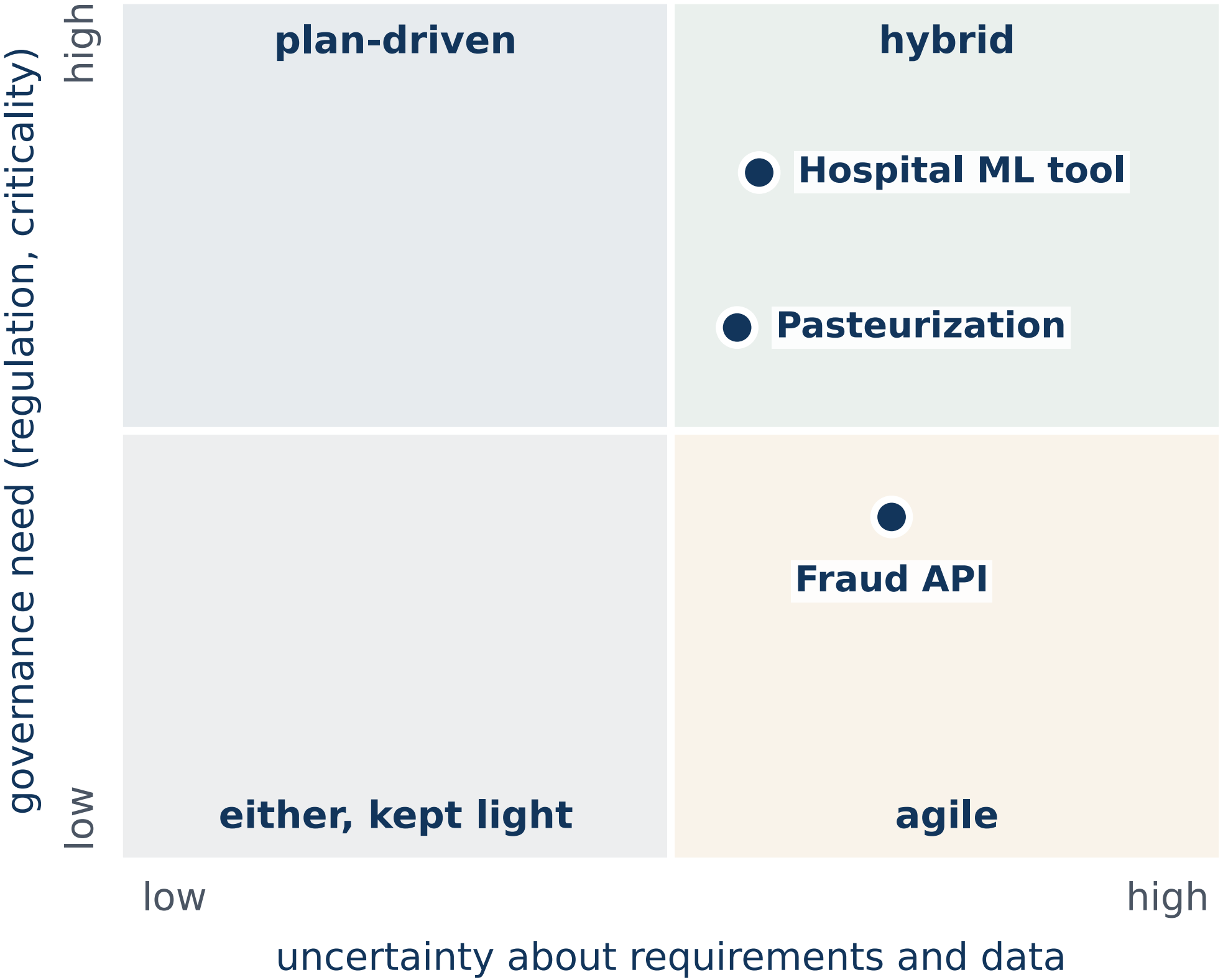illustrative placement: a judgment, not a measurement